

The colonization of Australia and the Pacific

European explorers first set sail to the Pacific Ocean in the 16th century. They encountered lush lands occupied by Indigenous communities who had lived there for 65,000 years. In the late 18th century, European powers began to seize control of Pacific lands, starting centuries of oppression.

The Indigenous peoples of the Pacific islands and Australia had built complex civilizations, with unique traditions and ways of life (see pp.80–81). Despite this, many Europeans considered these lands *terra nullius* (“lands belonging to no one”), to be used as they saw fit.

Colonizing Australia began in earnest in 1770 when Captain James Cook claimed it for Britain. By 1788, the British had set up a colony for exiled convicts, and an increasing

number of free settlers arrived from the 1820s. In New Zealand, the first official colony was set up in 1840.

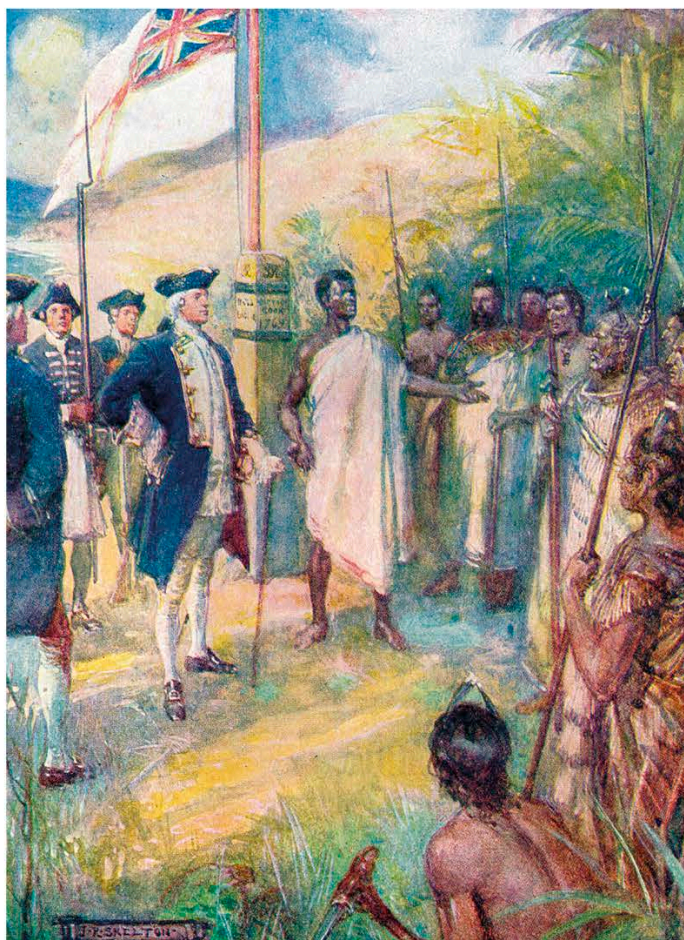
The arrival of Europeans had a devastating impact. Local populations were harmed by new diseases and violent conflict with the colonizers, who took their lands and tried to eliminate their cultures in order to increase their dominance.

Iron shackles used to keep prisoners from escaping on the journey to Australia



THE FIRST COLONISTS ▲

Most of the early colonists in Australia were convicts sent there to serve their time. They built roads and settlements, and prepared the new colonies for future settlers. After they finished their prison sentences, some people were allowed to buy land in the region, marry, and settle down.



◀ CAPTAIN COOK

The British explorer James Cook made three journeys to the Pacific between 1768 and 1779. He visited Tahiti, Australia, and New Zealand, where he became the first recorded European to meet the Māori people (left). His reports of these journeys played an important part in the European understanding of the inhabitants of these islands.

TAKE A LOOK

In the 20th century, the Australian government took many First Nations children from their communities and placed them with white families. Although they claimed this would improve the lives of the children, the purpose was to destroy Indigenous culture. The First Australians call these children the “Stolen Generations.”

